

FASCISM AND FREEDOM fighters

TOTALITARIAN REGIMES

In 1919, Benito Mussolini created the world's first fascist movement in Italy. His combat group extolled the virtues of masculinity and machismo, appealing to the fighting spirit and fervent patriotism of his fellow World War I veterans. The fascist "revolution" was presented as an entirely male event. Newsreels showed young men marching in formation and singing rousing fascist anthems celebrating nationhood, war, and empire.

Denying women a role in politics and public life, Italian fascism sought to keep women within the confines of the home, to limit their educational and employment opportunities, and to restrict their roles to those of wife and mother. Mussolini's official policies also imposed a state-sponsored system of "compulsory motherhood" upon women, with social incentives and welfare benefits aimed to convince them to become "breeders" to create new soldiers. One of the biggest fascist creations in Italy was the National Organization for the Protection of



◀ Blackshirts

Female members of the British Union of Fascists (founded by Oswald Mosley in 1932) wear the fascist uniform – the famous black shirt, alongside a beret and skirt – as they prepare for a rally in Liverpool, England.

Motherhood and Infancy, an institution which gave moral and financial support to pregnant women, mothers, and widows.

Despite the misogynistic ideology, women had a visible presence in fascist movements in some countries and were key to their success. In Britain, a distinct form of feminine fascism emerged, and a woman named Rotha Lintorn-Orman founded the first fascist movement in Britain in 1923.



"UNDER CONDITIONS OF TYRANNY IT IS FAR EASIER TO ACT THAN TO THINK".

HANNAH ARENDT, *THE HUMAN CONDITION*, 1958

► Call to arms

This depiction of a Catalan woman rallying troops was created in 1937 to encourage support for the Basque people, who were besieged by fascist and German forces during the Spanish Civil War.

